

Defensive Roll and Mitigation System

Initial Ideas and Concepts

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April 23, 2026

1 Initial Idea

The current setup in D20 systems has always bothered me with how it has a single roll that should encapsulate everything from dodging, to damage soaking on armor, to magical item/spell intervention impacting abilities to hit a target. Although seemingly streamlined, this seems to severely degrade the roll play experience¹ as most combat tends to - at least eventually - turn into just a sequence of "roll your hit. That hits, roll damage. You do X damage to the creature. Next." Which inevitably breaks the immersion and starts to promote the "who can get the biggest numbers" dopamine hit².

This document is intended to give a different combat mechanics that focuses fundamentally differently on how combat should run. It includes the system mechanics for a new combat system, along with role-play interpretations for what the system is intending to capture. This should allow one to pick subsystems if they want (although it is designed to be used all together, so picking specific subsystems may leads to unintended mechanical breakages allowing for min/maxing to get truly out of hand), but importantly it should also allow a DM (especially less experienced ones) a way to interpret in-game rolls and values in a way that captures the intended style of the player based on how they have decided to build their defense/offensive style.

1.1 The underlying premise

People rarely miss hitting things that aren't moving. This is one of my great pet-peeves about D20 systems that use an attack roll and something like "AC" that is some single defensive stat. It is difficult to determine if an attack hits, misses entirely, or hits but deals no damage because it is soaked into armor ("natural" or crafted). Often low rolls are interpreted as a straight miss, even in situations where the target is unable to dodge (paralyzed, tight quarters, etc). This is a byproduct of the natural viewpoint promoted by the "roll attack" - the action is on the attacker, and thus their success is almost always determined by their ability, rather than considering that whether an attack succeeds - or how it fails - often has more to do with the nature of the defender.

Thus the underlying premise of this combat system is that we should focus on the defender, rather than attacker, as the impetus for success or failure. In this system, attacks that can make contact, are assumed to make contact, unless the defender successfully avoids the attack. The nature of "avoid" can depend here, as it can be avoided in the sense that the attack itself is avoided (e.g. dodged entirely), or the contact can be avoided in the sense that something interposes itself between the object and the defender - e.g. armor can "soak" the contact, preventing the effect. This is discussed in greater detail in the [Dodge vs Soak section below](#)

¹The obvious exception being if you have a truly gifted DM that is able to write a story from the numbers and has intimate knowledge of how the characters individually prefer their defensive and offensives styles to be played out from a roll playing standpoint, which is a huge burden on the DM and I would argue, for a streamlining that is mechanically harmful to defensive and offensive style choices, as well as being not all that streamlined.

²Don't misunderstand here - if that is what you enjoy about the game, then live it up! The game is meant to be played for fun, and if this your source of fun, don't let anyone tell you it isn't. But not everyone likes this kind of min/max number chasing and to get pushed into it after significant effort to build an interesting character, it can feel like you are being penalized if you don't min/max.

2 Dodge vs Soak

2.1 Role-play Interpretation (Motivation)

2.2 Mechanics Ideas

3 Effects of Armor and Shields

3.1 Role-play Interpretation (Motivation)

3.2 Mechanics Ideas

4 Mechanical Balance for the Min/Maxers

4.1 Role-play Interpretation (Motivation)

4.2 Mechanics Ideas

5 Damage and Mitigation from Magic

5.1 Role-play Interpretation (Motivation)

5.2 Mechanics Ideas

6 Roll/Impact of Magic Items

6.1 Role-play Interpretation (Motivation)

6.2 Mechanics Ideas

7 Involving Martial "Special Abilities/Attacks"

7.1 Role-play Interpretation (Motivation)

7.2 Mechanics Ideas